In retrospect, Shah Shuja's reign marked the end of one world and the beginning of another. For, despite its many costly failures, the First Anglo-Afghan War had important and long-lasting effects. For the British it created a stable frontier. Within a few years, the British had absorbed the Punjab of the Sikh Khalsa and the lands of the lower Indus previously ruled by the Amirs of Sindh; but they had learned their lesson that Peshawar should be the North West Frontier of their Raj.

For the Afghans the war changed their state for ever: on his return, Dost Mohammad inherited the reforms made by the British and these helped him consolidate an Afghanistan that was much more clearly defined than it was before the war. Indeed Shuja and most of his contemporaries never used the word 'Afghanistan' – for him, there was a Kingdom of Kabul which was the last surviving fragment of the Durrani Empire and which lay on the edge of a geographical space he described as Khurasan. Yet within a generation the phrase Afghanistan existed widely on maps both in and outside the country and the people within that space were beginning to describe themselves as Afghans. The return of Shah Shuja and the failed colonial expedition which was mounted to reinstate him finally destroyed the power of the Sadozai dynasty and ended the last memories of the Durrani Empire that they had founded. In this way the war did much to define the modern boundaries of the Afghan state, and consolidated once and for all the idea of a country called Afghanistan.

If the First Afghan War helped consolidate the Afghan State, the question now is whether the current western intervention will contribute to its demise. At the time of writing, western troops are again poised to leave Afghanistan in the hands of a weak Popalzai-run government. It is impossible to predict the fate of either that regime or the fractured and divided state of Afghanistan. But what Mirza 'Ata wrote after 1842 remains equally true today: 'It is certainly no easy thing to invade or govern the Kingdom of Khurasan.'